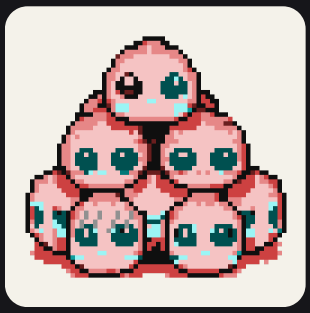
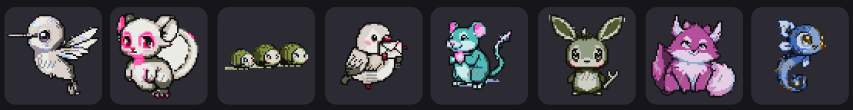
CONTEXT / CONTENT

DAEMONS

The player's manual







For release **v11.316.2**, 2026-10-28 · every word quoted from the game is a DRAFT
A fan project for the Game Boy Advance. No ROM is in it, or anywhere in DAEMONS.

Contents

1 Welcome to DAEMONS 4

Two editions, one game 4
A few words you will meet 5
Before you start 5

2 Ways to play 6

Patch your own cartridge 6
mGBA, on a computer 8
Delta, on an iPhone or iPad 8
A real Game Boy Advance 9
The one app, on an iPhone or iPad 9
The playground, in a browser 10
The DEBUG builds 11
Build it yourself 12
The classic Game Boy build 12
The companion 12

3 Getting started 13

The buttons 13
A new game 14
The menu 15
Saving 15
CHECKPOINTS and THE REPO 16
Getting about 16

4 The world 18

The clock 18
The seasons 19
The weather 20
Holidays 21
The SITEMAP 21
Colour is friendship 21
Places the game never points to 22
Music 22

5 Daemons 23

Binding 23
Your party 23
Routines 24
States 24
Growing 25
The daemon behind you 25

6 Battles and the type chart 26

The battle screen 26
The seventeen types 27
The chart 28
Weather in battle 29

7 BENCHMARKS, MARKS and ROOTS 30

The eight BENCHMARKS 30
The MARKS 30
ROOTS: what you come to understand 30
THE REVIEW BOARD 30

8 The INDEX 31

Every entry, twice 32
What an entry holds 32
OPUS, and the GLOBAL INDEX 32

9 The NOTEBOOK and CALLOW SCHOOL 33

The NOTEBOOK 33
The DREAM LOG 33
THE LOG 33
CALLOW SCHOOL 33

10 The books 34

THE PROGRAMMER'S GUIDE TO THE HUMAN MIND 34
THE SUBTLE LAYER 34

11 The subtle layer, in play 35

The daemon notices first 35
Reads 35
Leans 36
Words under words 36
Out here too 37

12 PLAY: the HARP and the FLUTE 38

Seven songs 38

13 The GAME CORNER and the CASINO 39

The GAME CORNER 39
The CASINO 39

14 The companion 40

SEND, AWAY and home 40
Where a daemon can live 41
What it shows of your game 42
Nights and dreams 42
Running it 43

15 Help 44

Something went wrong 44
Updating to a new release 44
Reporting a bug 45

16 Glossary 46

17 About this manual 47

CHAPTER 1

Welcome to DAEMONS

DAEMONS is a total conversion of *Pokémon FireRed* and *LeafGreen* for the Game Boy Advance. Machines evolved into creatures, and this is a game about what happened next. You keep an INDEX, you bind DAEMONS, you run them against other USERS, and you work your way through eight BENCHMARKS -- and almost everything is written down somewhere.



The opening, as a new game begins. CRYSTAL CLEAR keeps the lab in your home town.

Two editions, one game

The slash in the title is literal. **CONTEXT** and **CONTENT** are two editions built from one source, the way Red and Blue, and FireRed and LeafGreen, always were.

	CONTENT	**CONTEXT**
made from	*FireRed*	*LeafGreen*
leans toward, early	CONTENT, LOGIC, STRATUM, LEGACY	CONTEXT, LATENT, VECTOR, ENTROPY
its year	a northern one	a southern one, two seasons on
its instrument	the HARP	the FLUTE
its INDEX	every entry, in its own words	every entry, in other words

Both tell the same story in the same towns, and every daemon exists in both. They differ in which daemons you meet, in what the INDEX says about them, in the year they keep and in what you play. **The type chart is the same, byte for byte, in both -**

- that never changes. And because each edition cannot bind some daemons, finishing the INDEX takes someone else's game: another player's context, over a link cable.

A few words you will meet

DAEMONS renames almost everything. The game never stops to explain its words; this table does, once.

you knew	here it is
Pokémon	**DAEMON**
Pokédex	**THE INDEX**
Trainer	**USER**
wild	**UNBOUND**
catching	**BINDING**
Poké Ball	**USERBOX**
moves	**ROUTINES**
fainted	**HALTED**
evolution	**RECOMPILE**
run away	**DETACH**

you knew	here it is
Gym	**BENCHMARK**
Badge	**MARK**
Elite Four	**THE REVIEW BOARD**
Pokémon Center	**CHECKPOINT**
Poké Mart	**THE REPO**
PC storage	**COLD STORAGE**, the **PORT**
Bag	**POOL**
TM, HM	**PLUGIN**, **DRIVER**
Town Map	**SITEMAP**
Prof. Oak	**CRYSTAL CLEAR**

The glossary at the back has the rest.

Before you start

> **DAEMONS is a fan project, and no ROM is ever shared.** It is published as small **patches** that you apply to a *FireRed* or *LeafGreen* ROM you made from **your own cartridge**. Nobody in the project can give you a ROM; please don't ask anyone else for one.

> **Every word quoted from the game in this manual is a DRAFT**, as the game's own words are until each is approved. The pictures are real: each game screen was captured from a built ROM, and each daemon is drawn from the build this manual was made with (v11.316.2, against the design bible v11.316). The game changes often, so a screen here may be a release or two behind the one you play.

This manual tells you **how** things work. It never tells you **where** anything is: finding things is the game, and some places in it are mentioned by nothing at all.

CHAPTER 2

Ways to play

DAEMONS runs anywhere a *FireRed* does, and a few places besides. Pick the way that suits you; the game is the same in every one, and a save can move between most of them.

you have	the way to play
your own *FireRed* or *LeafGreen* cartridge	patch your own ROM, then any of the ways below
a computer	mGBA
an iPhone or iPad	Delta, or the one app (in testing)
a Game Boy Advance	a flash cartridge
a browser, on a network someone runs it on	the playground
the source, and a Mac or Linux machine	build it yourself, the DEBUG builds and the classic Game Boy build
a phone, a watch or a board, alongside any of these	the companion

Patch your own cartridge

A patch is a short list of differences. Applied to the ROM it was made for, it turns that ROM into DAEMONS: *FireRed* becomes **CONTENT**, *LeafGreen* becomes **CONTEXT**. A patch checks the ROM before it changes anything, so the wrong one simply refuses -- it cannot harm your file.

1. Back up your cartridge

Any GBA cartridge reader makes a copy of it, a *dump* (a GB Operator, a GBxCart RW, or a Nintendo DS Lite with a homebrew dumping tool). Save it as a `.gba` file.

2. Find the patch that fits it

Each game was printed twice, as **1.0** and **Rev 1**, and a patch fits only the exact ROM it was made from. A patcher shows your ROM's CRC32 and SHA-1 the moment you open it; they must match one row.

your ROM	CRC32	SHA-1 begins	the patch
FireRed (USA) **1.0**	`DD88761C`	`41cb23d8dccc…`	DAEMONS.CONTENT.for.FireRed.1.0.bps
FireRed (USA, Europe) **Rev 1**	`84EE4776`	`dd5945db9b93…`	DAEMONS.CONTENT.for.FireRed.Rev.1.bps
LeafGreen (USA) **1.0**	`D69C96CC`	`574fa542ffeb…`	DAEMONS.CONTEXT.for.LeafGreen.1.0.bps
LeafGreen (USA, Europe) **Rev 1**	`DAFFECEC`	`7862c67bdecb…`	DAEMONS.CONTEXT.for.LeafGreen.Rev.1.bps

Other regions, ROMs that are already patched and bad dumps will not match. The full table, with every checksum and the MD5s too, is `ROM RELEASE/HOW_TO_PATCH.md` in the repository.

3. Download it and apply it

Take the newest release from **github.com/CodeMusic/DAEMONS/releases** and download the one `.bps` under **Assets** that matches your row. Then, in a browser on any computer or phone, open **Rom Patcher JS** (marcrobledo.com/RomPatcher.js): choose your ROM, then the patch, then **Apply patch**. It runs on your own device and uploads nothing. Floating IPS, MultiPatch and RetroArch's own patching all work as well.

Keep your clean original. Every new release is applied to the original, never to a ROM you already patched. Give the new DAEMONS ROM the same file name as the old one, and your emulator or cartridge finds the same save. Copy your `.sav` somewhere safe first: releases are built to keep saves working, and a backup costs nothing.

mGBA, on a computer

The emulator DAEMONS is built and tested in

mGBA (mgba.io) runs on Windows, macOS and Linux. Open your patched ROM and play. It can also **soft-patch**: put the `.bps` beside your clean ROM under the same name (`FireRed.gba` and `FireRed.bps`) and mGBA applies it every time it loads, leaving the ROM untouched.

Its keys, until you change them (Settings, Keyboard): **X** is A, **Z** is B, **Enter** is START, **Backspace** is SELECT, **A** and **S** are L and R, and the arrows move.

The clock. DAEMONS reads a cartridge clock, and mGBA gives it one from your computer's. mGBA keeps that clock in 16 bytes at the end of the save, so its saves are 131,088 bytes rather than 131,072. If the game's date ever looks wrong, see Help.

Delta, on an iPhone or iPad

Patch in Safari, play in Delta

Delta can't patch by itself. Patch in Safari with Rom Patcher JS, which saves the result to **Files**; then in Delta, press **+** and import the patched file. Delta keeps its own save for it.

A new game, or a busy moment, can hold a black screen for a few seconds on a phone. Give it time before deciding it has stopped.

A real Game Boy Advance

With a flash cartridge

A flash cartridge -- an EZ-Flash, an EverDrive and the like -- plays the patched ROM on the hardware itself. Copy the patched `.gba` to its SD card.

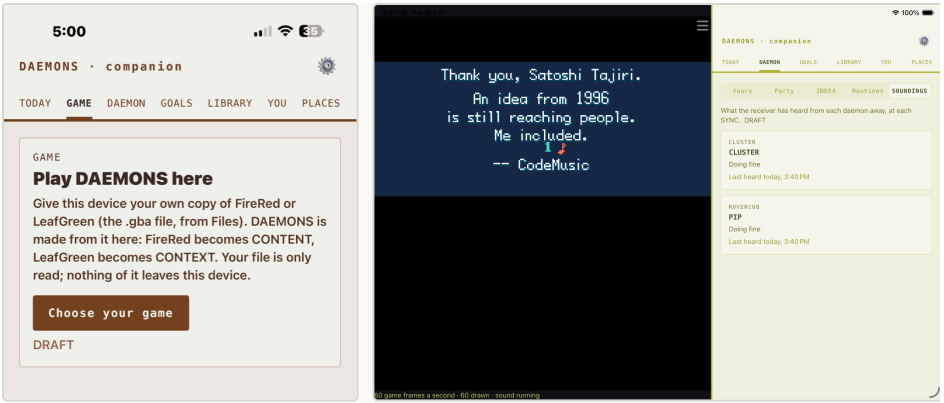
- **Save type:** leave it on automatic. DAEMONS saves exactly as *FireRed* does, 128 KB of flash.
- **The clock:** if the cartridge has a clock battery, switch its clock (RTC) **on** for this game in the cartridge's own menu, and set the time there. Then, at the terminal in your bedroom, type **TIME**: a **CLOCK** line with today's date means the game is reading it. Without a clock the game still plays, and its days follow your play time.
- **Updating:** the save sits beside the ROM on the SD card as its own `.sav` (an EZ-Flash Omega keeps it in `SAVER`), matched by **file name**. Copy it off first, then replace the `.gba` with the new one under the same name. The cart writes the save to the card when you next boot or reset into its menu, so do that before taking the card out.

The one app, on an iPhone or iPad

The game and the companion together (in testing)

The companion's own app can hold the game. Give it your own *FireRed* or *LeafGreen* once, from Files: it recognises the ROM, fetches the matching patch from the newest release, applies it **on the device**, checks the result, and plays it in a **GAME** tab, with your original kept untouched beside it. A newer release is offered with one tap.

The game's save is the companion's. Showing the companion pauses the game; SEND and SYNC write the save, and the game carries on from it. On an iPad on its side, the game sits on the left and the companion beside it, and a NOTEBOOK page just filed or the INDEX card of a daemon just met opens next to the game.



The GAME tab before a game is given, on an iPhone; and an iPad on its side, the game beside the companion (the iPad simulator, a made-up save).

Internal and in testing for now: it is built and run on the project's own iPhone and iPads, and is not on the App Store or TestFlight. A Mac version is planned. More in the companion.

The playground, in a browser

The game in a browser, for demos and beta tests

daemons-playground plays DAEMONS in a browser from one address: choose an edition (or its DEBUG build), start a new game or continue from a `.sav`, and play -- with the keyboard on a computer, or buttons on the screen on a phone. Beside the game, in tabs: a companion of its own for the daemons you SEND, each release's notes, and help.

It is never a public site. Whoever runs it serves the ROMs they built themselves, and it answers only their own machine, their private network and their tailnet. If someone runs one for you, open the address they give you.

on a computer	
arrows	move
X / **Z**	A / B
Enter / **V**	START / SELECT
Q / **E**	L / R

On an iPhone, sound may only start inside a tap, so the page puts **TAP TO PLAY** over the game; that tap starts it. The game keeps its save in the browser, and **a `.sav` can be downloaded** at any time.

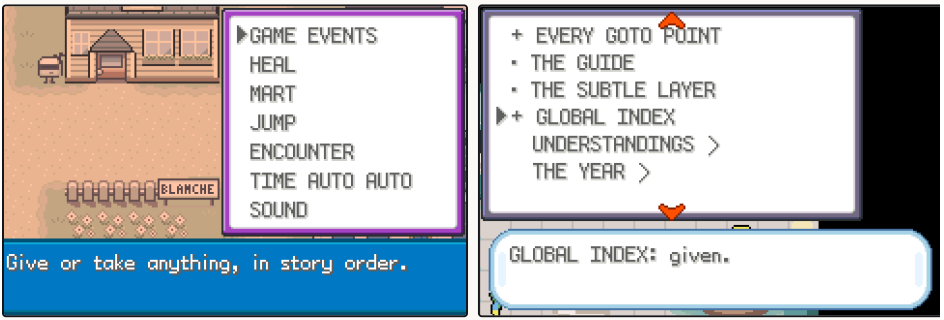
To run one, with DAEMONS and its releases built on the machine, from the DAEMONS folder:

```
playground/bindPlayground.sh          # the newest release, on port 4740
playground/bindPlayground.sh --build  # this machine's own build instead
```

The DEBUG builds

For testing, not for a first play

Each edition has a **testing build**, `daemonsContent_debug.gba` and `daemonsContext_debug.gba`, with a save of its own so testing never touches a playthrough. A new game starts as a normal one does; its START menu has one more row, **DEBUG**: "*Testing tools. Not part of the game.*"



DEBUG's first page, and GAME EVENTS: the story's pieces, each given or taken in story order.

- **GAME EVENTS** hands the game out a piece at a time, in story order, each row marked **+** when held and **·** when not: everything at once, the roster, every daemon, the MARKS, the NOTEBOOK, the books and more.
- **JUMP** reaches a place without playing to it. **ENCOUNTER** sets the season and the weather. **TIME** (the watch) forces dawn, day, dusk or night. **SOUND** plays any song or sound. **HEAL** and **MART** do what they say.
- Hold **B** to walk through tall grass without meeting anything.

The testing builds are not published with the releases. Build one yourself (below), or play it in the playground.

Build it yourself

From the source, on a Mac or Linux machine. DAEMONS is three repositories joined by links: the design and its tools, and the two engines, which are kept beside it and never merged in.

```
git clone https://github.com/CodeMusic/DAEMONS.git
cd DAEMONS
./setup.sh                # the engines beside it, the links, and the agbcc compiler
./bindDaemons.sh          # build CONTENT and open it in mGBA
./bindDaemons.sh context  # CONTEXT
./bindDaemons.sh --debug  # the testing build
```

You need `arm-none-eabi-gcc` (Homebrew's works) and **agbcc**, which `setup.sh` builds. The ROMs come out as `engineGba/daemonsContent.gba` and `engineGba/daemonsContext.gba`. **A build you make is for you alone** -- it carries Nintendo's engine, so it is never shared; what the project publishes is patches.

The classic Game Boy build

> **Where DAEMONS began**
>
> DAEMONS was first built on the original Game Boy, on *Red* and *Blue*, and moved to the GBA in September 2026. The Game Boy build still compiles and still plays its opening stretch, the *vertical slice*, in both editions. It is kept as a reference and **is not updated any more**; the GBA game is the real one.

```
./bindDaemons.sh --classic          # CONTENT on the Game Boy, opened in SameBoy
./bindDaemons.sh context --classic  # CONTEXT
```

It needs RGBDS. Expect fewer daemons, the old greyscale-and-colour look, and none of what the GBA game has grown since.

The companion

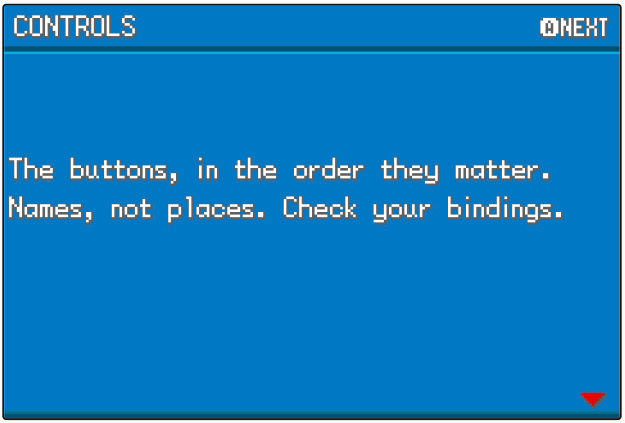
Not a way to play the game itself, but a way to take a daemon out of it: your phone, a watch or a small board can **host** a daemon you SEND from your party, and bring it home again. It works beside every way above that keeps a save you can reach. It has a chapter of its own.

CHAPTER 3

Getting started

The buttons

The game opens on its own page about them: "*The buttons, in the order they matter. Names, not places. Check your bindings.*"



The first page of a new game.

button	what it does
+ Control Pad	moves you; chooses in menus
A	confirms, checks things, talks, turns the page of a message
B	goes back, cancels; in the DEBUG build, held, walks through tall grass
START	opens the menu
SELECT	moves things in a list; uses the item you registered
L, **R**	help, outside battle; **in battle**, L opens the INDEX and R shows PERSPECTIVE

A new game

CRYSTAL CLEAR introduces herself and the world. Then she asks a question: "*When these disagree, which of them do you follow?*" -- **REASON** or **INSTINCT**. Your answer is who you play. Then you choose your name, and your rival's.



Your room

CRYSTAL CLEAR, the question answered, and your room as the game begins.

Your room has a terminal. Type **TIME** at it and it tells you what clock the game is reading: a **CLOCK** line with the date when there is a real clock (a cartridge's or an emulator's), and play time when there is not.

Your first daemon comes from CRYSTAL CLEAR's lab, one of three, each a different way of learning:

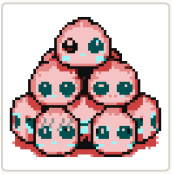


LABEL No. 004

EXAMPLE DAEMON **CONTENT**

CONTENT Holds one example and the answer that came with it. Someone else decided what it means. It has never met them.

CONTEXT Every answer it gives was decided once, by somebody, a long time ago.



CLUSTER No. 007

GROUPING DAEMON **VECTOR**

CONTENT Puts near things with near things. Nobody told it which things matter. It has guessed. Nobody checked the guess.

CONTEXT Things it put together are treated alike from then on. They were only near.



ROVERCUB No. 001

PORTABLE DAEMON **GROWTH**

CONTENT Small enough to carry. Learns from what it is carried past. It has no way to choose the route. It remembers it.

CONTEXT Whoever carried it chose what it knows. They did not think of it as choosing.

The menu

START opens it, in two columns.





The START menu (this is the testing build, so DEBUG is in it; the game you play has no DEBUG row), and your USER card. Each row of the menu explains itself in the line along the bottom.

INDEX	every daemon you have seen and bound -- its chapter
DAEMONS	your party of up to six, and what each can do outside battle
POOL	your bag: items, key items, PLUGINS and more, in pockets
your name	your USER card: your MARKS, the day and the clock
SAVE	a complete record of your progress
OPTION	text speed, sound, the battle style, and **FOLLOWER** on or off
HELP	how to play, and how to do things (L and R open it too)

Saving

SAVE from the START menu writes one complete record. There is one save for each ROM, kept by your emulator or cartridge beside the ROM. Save often, and back the `.sav` file up before you update to a new release.

CHECKPOINTS and THE REPO

A **CHECKPOINT** restores your daemons, health and state together, free; it is where you return when every daemon you carry has HALTED. Upstairs in each, someone will tell you about the companion. **THE REPO** sells what you need: items to repair a daemon, USERBOXES to bind one, and more as you go.



A CHECKPOINT, and the PORT, where daemons you are not carrying wait in COLD STORAGE.

Your PC is a **PORT**. Booted at a CHECKPOINT or at home, it opens **COLD STORAGE**, where every daemon you bind past your six goes, in boxes, and your own items' store.

Getting about

Some routines work outside battle as well as in it. Taught by a **DRIVER**, they open the way:

routine	outside battle
PRUNE	cuts a thin tree back
CRACK	breaks a cracked rock
DISPLACE	moves a boulder
TRAVERSE	crosses water, riding out on a manta
ASCEND	climbs a waterfall
VERBOSE	lights a dark cave
GOTO	takes you to a CHECKPOINT you have already reached -- you come apart into bits and notes and arrive

And a few items: the **BICYCLE**; the **SITEMAP**, the map of everywhere; **EJECT**, out of a cave; **SUPPRESS**, to keep unbound daemons away for a while; **GREP**, which finds hidden items nearby.

CHAPTER 4

The world

The world keeps time, turns through the seasons, has weather and keeps the real calendar's holidays. Nothing in the game explains any of it -- you notice.



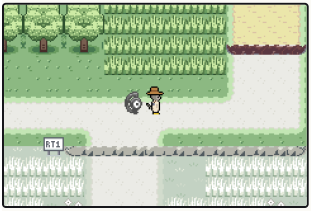
A town by day.

The clock

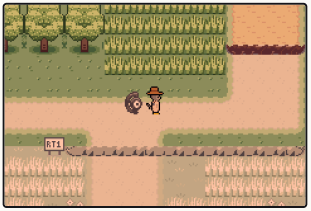
With a clock (an emulator's, or a cartridge's switched on) the game follows the real hour. Without one, an hour of play is a day.

	hours
dawn	5 to 7
day	7 to 18
dusk	18 to 20
night	20 to 5

The light tints the outdoor maps as the day goes. The weekday is on your USER card.



Day



Dusk

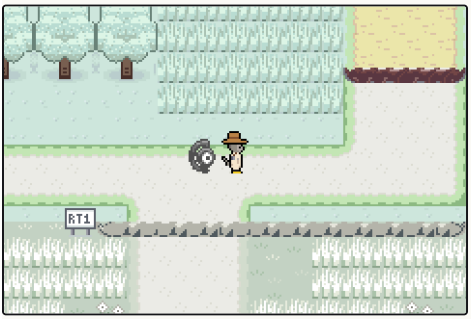


Night

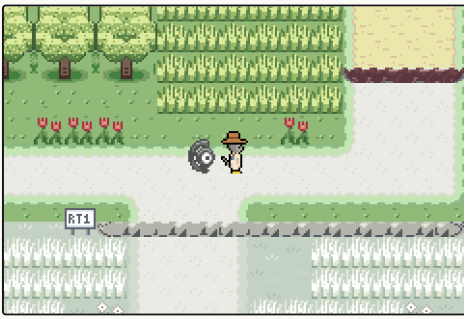
The same road by day, at dusk and at night.

The seasons

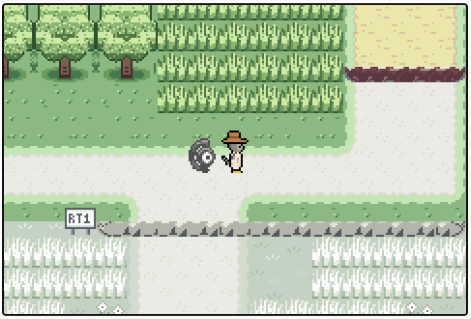
The seasons repaint the world, and the two editions live in **two hemispheres**: CONTENT keeps a northern year and CONTEXT a southern one, so in the same week one player's world is in spring and the other's in autumn. On many early roads the tall grass changes with them -- one of its daemons belongs to the season and one to the hour -- so some are met only at a time of year, or a time of day.



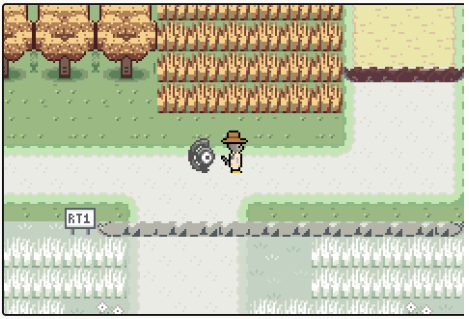
Winter



Spring



Summer

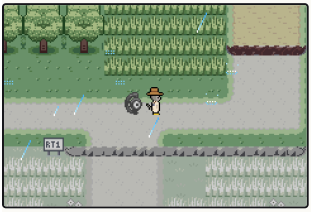


Autumn

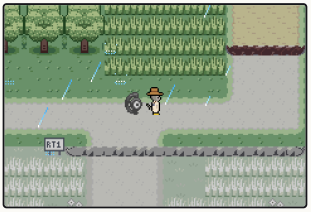
One road through CONTENT's year.

The weather

The weather follows the season, over the ordinary outdoor maps. It is drawn from the date, so two players in the same edition on the same day see the same sky. A spell can begin at any minute, last from ten minutes to a whole day, and cover one town or the whole region. Most of the time the sky is clear.



Rain



Storm



Snow

Spring brings rain and storms; winter, snow.



Fog



Wind

Autumn brings fog, and WIND.

season	its weather
spring	rain, and storms
summer	storms; most days clear
autumn	fog, and WIND
winter	snow

The weather reaches into battle too -- see battles -- and some daemons come out only in one. The INDEX says so.

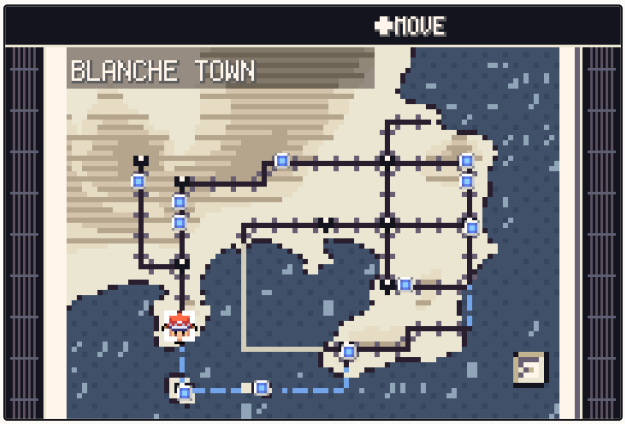
Holidays

The game keeps the real calendar's holidays, under the world's own names: **three a month**, one shared by both editions, one for CONTENT's northern year and one for CONTEXT's southern. Playing on one changes the game a little and never gates it: its own light and sky, some daemons turning up more on their day, fireworks, and a gift once a year. On two days a year each edition lets in the other's daemons.

Every month has a colour and a note. The months run up the scale from January's C, red, to December's B, purple. The day's banner and your USER card show them, and on the 1st the banner plays the month's note. What you are told on a holiday is kept in **THE YEAR**, in your NOTEBOOK.

The SITEMAP

The **SITEMAP**, in your POOL's key items, is the map of everywhere. Register it to SELECT and it opens with one press. It keeps the region's shape, so finding your way is unchanged, but it is drawn in the game's own look: paper and ink, routes like a score, and the sea a shuffle of bits and notes.



The SITEMAP, open on your home town.

Colour is friendship

A daemon's colours fill as it comes to trust you: nearly grey, with a hint of its type, at first; half its colour once it is friendly; the whole of it at the most. People keep their colour. Some trainers' daemons never warm to anyone.

Places the game never points to

Some places in DAEMONS are mentioned by no sign and no one. Finding them is the game. If you find one, please keep it out of bug reports, so the next player can find it too.

Music

Each town has its key. Four have themes of their own, and each hidden place has a loop of its own.

CHAPTER 5

Daemons

Binding

Walk in tall grass, in caves or on the water and an **UNBOUND** daemon may announce itself. Weaken it, then offer it a box and see whether it will run there. The boxes climb a ladder of privilege, each binding more surely than the last:

USERBOX	where everyone starts
ADMINBOX	better
SUPERBOX	better again
ROOTBOX	never fails

A daemon you bind joins your party of six, or goes to COLD STORAGE when the party is full. Binding a daemon writes it into the INDEX as **owned**; meeting one writes it as **seen**.

Your party

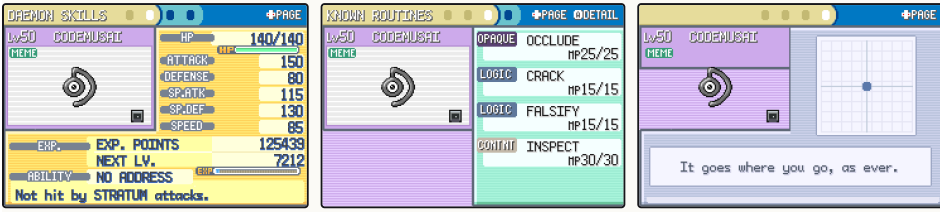


Your party, and a daemon's first page: its number, name and type, its USER and where you met it.

Each daemon has four pages. **L** and **R**, or left and right, turn them:

- **DAEMON INFO** -- its number, name and type, its USER and ID No., its nature, and where you met it.
- **DAEMON SKILLS** -- health, its five statistics, experience, and its ability and what it does.

- **KNOWN ROUTINES** -- its four routines, each with its type and how many times it can run.
- **A fourth page for how it is.** A daemon feels things -- glad, cross, low, calm, afraid -- from what happens to it in play. The page shows it as a place on a grid and a line, never as a word: the game never names a feeling, and a feeling is never a status.



Its skills, its routines, and how it is: "It goes where you go, as ever."

Routines

A daemon knows up to four **ROUTINES**, learned as it grows or taught by a **PLUGIN** (kept in the **TOOLKIT**) or a **DRIVER**. Each routine has a type, and a small mark beside its name for what it does: strike, raise, lower, afflict, mend or guard. Every routine also carries a signature of its own in battle -- a few glyphs of bits, and a three-note figure in its type's key.

States

A daemon can be left in one of six states, and items undo them:

state	what it does	undone by
LEAKING	loses a little health every turn	**PATCH**
CASCADING	loses more every turn	**PATCH**
SUSPENDED	does nothing until it resumes	**RESUME**
THROTTLED	slowed, and sometimes stalls	**PRIORITY**
OVERHEATED	takes damage, and hits softer	**COOLANT**
HUNG	does nothing until something intervenes	**PREEMPT**

THRASHING passes when the battle ends. **ROLLBACK** clears every state; **RECOVER** restores health; **SNAPSHOT** restores both. A daemon whose health runs out has **HALTED**: **RESTART** starts it again with half its health, **REBOOT** with all of it.

Growing

Battles give a daemon experience; levels make it stronger and teach it routines. At the right moment a daemon **RECOMPILES** -- it becomes the next thing in its line. Most do it by level; some need an item, some a trade, some trust, and some an hour of the day.

The daemon behind you

The daemon at the head of your party walks behind you, drawn at your own size. Press **A** on it and it tells you how it is -- how much it trusts you, and how it feels, in a line of its own; it notices the weather, the hour and the season. It hides on the water and goes into a CHECKPOINT's machine while it is healed. **OPTION** turns it off.

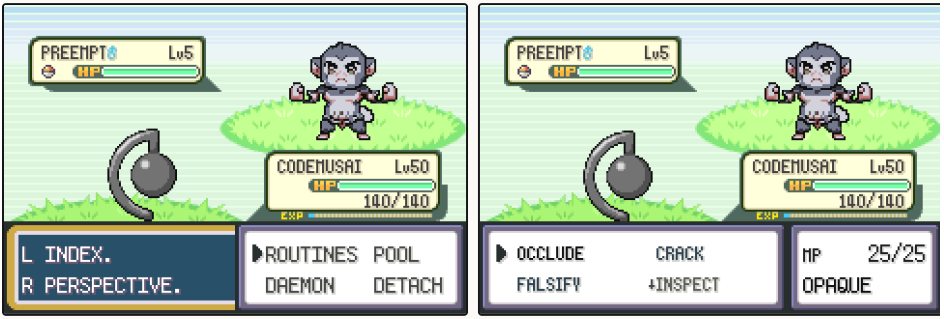


Talking to the daemon behind you.

CHAPTER 6

Battles and the type chart

The battle screen



A wild PREEMPT. For the first two seconds of every battle the question gives way to a reminder of L and R; then the routines.

ROUTINES	choose one of your daemon's four
POOL	use an item
DAEMON	send out another
DETACH	get away, from an unbound daemon
L, in battle	the INDEX entry of the daemon you are facing
R, held	**PERSPECTIVE**: the same fight, drawn from the other side, for as long as you hold it

The seventeen types

Every daemon has a type, or two, and so does every routine. The types are the vocabulary of thinking machines; each has a one-line idea that tells you how it behaves.

CONTENT	the thing itself, with nothing read into it
LOGIC	formal rules applied step by step; proof, not intuition
VECTOR	a direction that never touches the ground
CORRUPT	data that has been tampered with
STRATUM	the physical layer everything else runs on
LEGACY	old material that everything else has had time to work on
SWARM	many small agents; no single one matters
LATENT	running below the surface, unobserved
ENTROPY	noise and heat; disorder that spreads
FLOW	everything running downhill to the lowest point
GROWTH	training: fitting to whatever it is fed
SIGNAL	raw current, before anything interprets it
CONTEXT	the frame you read a thing in – what makes the same thing mean differently
FROZEN	locked to what it already saw, unable to move
EMERGENT	the behaviour nobody designed and nobody can account for
HARDENED	material chosen to resist, and it gave up everything else to do it
OPAQUE	a box you cannot see inside

The chart

Read across from the attacking routine's type to the defending daemon's. **2** hits twice as hard, ½ half as hard, and **0** not at all. A blank is an ordinary hit.

attacking ↓ defending →	CONTENT	LOGIC	VECTOR	CORRUPT	STRATUM	LEGACY	SWARM	LATENT	ENTROPY	FLOW	GROWTH	SIGNAL	CONTEXT	FROZEN	EMERGENT	HARDENED	OPAQUE
CONTENT						½		0								½	
LOGIC	2		½	½		2	½	0					½	2		2	2
VECTOR		2				½	2				2	½				½	
CORRUPT				½	½	½		½			2					0	
STRATUM			0	2		2	½		2		½	2				2	
LEGACY		½	2		½		2		2					2		½	
SWARM		½	½	½				½	½		2		2			½	2
LATENT	0							2					2			½	½
ENTROPY						½	2		½	½	2			2	½	2	
FLOW					2	2			2	½	½				½		
GROWTH			½	½	2	2	½		½	2	½				½	½	
SIGNAL			2		0					2	½	½			½		
CONTEXT		2		2				2					½			½	0
FROZEN			2		2				½	½	2			½	2	½	
EMERGENT															2	½	
HARDENED						2			½	½		½		2		½	
OPAQUE		½						2					2			½	½

All 111 relations, read from the game's own table. It is the same in both editions.

A daemon of two types takes both readings, multiplied: twice and twice is four times, twice and half is ordinary, and a 0 in either is 0. A routine of the daemon's own type hits half as hard again.

Weather in battle

Weather never touches the chart, but each kind lifts its own routines a quarter stronger, and the battle takes its tint:

weather	lifts
storm	**SIGNAL**
fog	**LATENT**
WIND	**VECTOR**

Snow falls as hail.

CHAPTER 7

BENCHMARKS, MARKS and ROOTS

The eight BENCHMARKS

Eight towns have a **BENCHMARK**, and a leader who runs it. Each tests one thing, mechanically: its lesson is in how the fight works, so it cannot simply be out-levelled. Pass it and you earn its **MARK**.

The MARKS

There are **eight MARKS**, and each prints a **virtue over its shadow** -- a MARK is a lesson as much as a badge. They show on your USER card. Each MARK also lets your daemons do more outside battle, and lets daemons you were given obey you to a higher level.

ROOTS: what you come to understand

The quest has two halves. The MARKS are one. The other is the **understandings**, seven of them, arrived at rather than won: some of what the game teaches comes quietly and is never announced. Each understanding held shows as a **ROOT** on your USER card, in its own colour.

A MARK and its ROOT pair. Once you hold both, its leader has more to say, and a **union PLUGIN** comes with it -- a routine no one teaches otherwise. When a pair is held, an **insight** may arrive on a later step; and when every pair is held, a last note.

> The **STREAM** in your POOL replays every lesson a MARK or a ROOT has opened, as many times as you like.

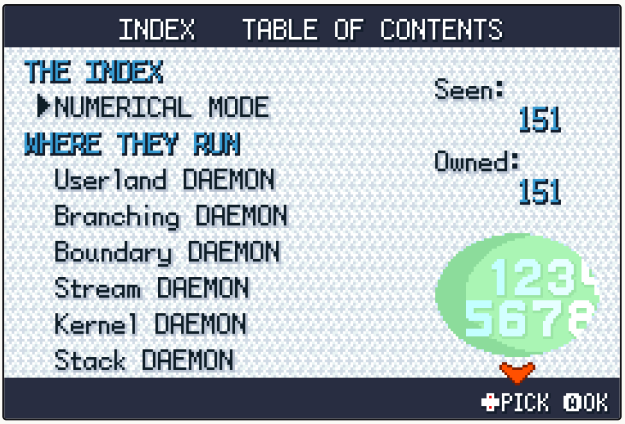
THE REVIEW BOARD

With eight MARKS the road leads to **THE REVIEW BOARD**, four reviewers in a row, and then the one who holds the place they guard.

CHAPTER 8

The INDEX

THE INDEX records every daemon you meet. CRYSTAL CLEAR gives it to you early; it starts empty.



The INDEX's contents: seen and owned, by number, by kind, and by where they run.

Every entry, twice

Each of the INDEX's entries is written **twice**, once for each edition, and the two disagree: different flat sentences about the same creature, and for some, different heights and weights, each stated as fact. Nobody in the game explains it.



PING No. 021

DEMAND DAEMON CONTENT VECTOR

CONTENT Asks one question and requires an answer. The question is: are you there. It asks again. It has always asked.

CONTEXT Anything that answers is counted as alive. Anything that does not is removed from the list.



NIBBLE No. 019

UNIT DAEMON CONTENT

CONTENT Four bits. The smallest piece the Index will file on its own. There are a great many. No two are filed together.

CONTEXT Every larger thing in the Index is built out of them. None of them is credited.

What an entry holds

- its **number**, **name**, **category** and **types**; its height and weight;
- its entry, in your edition's words;
- **NATIVE**: where it lives -- a region, and when it keeps to them, its edition (CONTENT ONLY, CONTEXT ONLY), its hours, its seasons and its weather (IN RAIN). NOT IN THE WILD means you will not meet it unbound;
- **FIRST MET** and **BOUND**: where you first saw it, and how it joined you.

In battle, **L** opens the entry of the daemon you are facing.

OPUS, and the GLOBAL INDEX

The INDEX can be opened further. **OPUS**, once you have it, adds a margin to each entry (press SELECT on an entry). At first the INDEX holds only the region's first 151; later in the story, the **GLOBAL INDEX** takes it past them.

CHAPTER 9

The NOTEBOOK and CALLOW SCHOOL

The NOTEBOOK

The **NOTEBOOK** keeps the pages you find and the pages you write, in sections: school notes, loose pages, lab notes, letters, the **SONGBOOK**, **THE YEAR** and more. Each page says where it was found, and a page you have not read yet carries a dot. A few end on a **QR code**: scan it with a phone, and it opens a song.

> This manual shows no NOTEBOOK page: what they say is for you to read in the game.

The DREAM LOG

After certain moments, at the next dawn, you say "*I had a dream.*" -- and the dream is filed in the NOTEBOOK as a picture with a title, never with an interpretation. Some dreams kept there are other people's.

ITS DREAMS. A daemon carried on a watch dreams while it sleeps there. At the next SYNC its dream comes home into your save, and at the next dawn it is filed under **ITS DREAMS** -- titled, never explained.

THE LOG

Once you carry THE SUBTLE LAYER, **THE LOG** counts the reads and leans you were given, and which of them came true. Only the log decides. See the subtle layer.

CALLOW SCHOOL

CALLOW SCHOOL has seven floors, a **TEXTBOOK**, and an **EXAM** you can leave halfway and come back to. Pass it and you earn a **DIPLOMA**, which opens doors elsewhere. Your NOTEBOOK keeps your school notes.

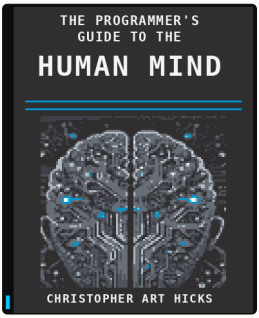
CHAPTER 10

The books

DAEMONS has two books to find and read: **THE PROGRAMMER'S GUIDE TO THE HUMAN MIND** and **THE SUBTLE LAYER**. Both are adapted from the author's own books and rewritten for the game's world, and every word of both is still a draft. Each stays hidden until you find it. The game never says where, and neither does this manual.

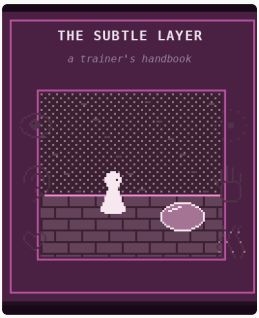
Once your save holds a book, you read it from your POOL's key items, a page at a time -- and the companion's LIBRARY opens it too, as a book: its cover, its contents, then each page in turn, with READ ALOUD.

THE PROGRAMMER'S GUIDE TO THE HUMAN MIND



The mind treated as software, written as an engineer's manual: the brain is the hardware, and thoughts, feelings and habits are code that can be read, debugged and rewritten. Its tools come from NLP, CBT, mindfulness, hypnotherapy and journaling, each set out as a way of working on the system, in 28 chapters from *Understanding the Mind as Software* to *The Path Forward*. Its page on security sets out each day's **virtue over its shadow** -- the same pairs your MARKS print.

THE SUBTLE LAYER



A trainer's handbook: what trainers do with the layer under the solid world, and what they notice when they do it. It holds the craft and the physics side by side and chooses neither -- reading (the clairs), steering (the psi) and bonding, what the physics allows, belief and the words that shape it, balancing mind and body, a routine for the week, and how to stay correctable. Every page has a picture, and in **TWO VOICES** a second, asking voice is printed faint.

Once you carry it, you start to notice things. The next chapter is about them.

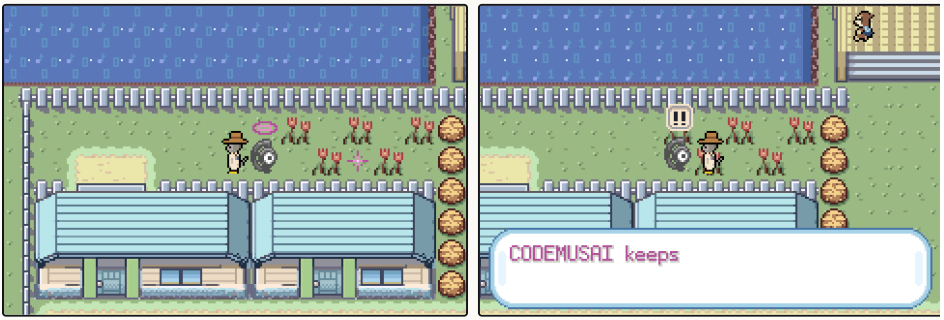
CHAPTER 11

The subtle layer, in play

Carry THE SUBTLE LAYER and the game shows you small things it never showed before, each marked in the book's **purple**. Not every one lands. The NOTEBOOK's **THE LOG** keeps the count of what you were told and what came true, and only the log decides.

The daemon notices first

Now and then the daemon behind you stops, turns, and a **purple ripple** rises from it, with a glint where it looks: something is there that you have not found yet. Press A on it, and what it says comes in purple.



The ripple, and the line that follows it.

Reads

As you arrive somewhere, a read may come to you: "**A read:**" and a line -- someone close by, rain before long. Some reads are about nothing, worded the same. When the thing it named happens, THE LOG marks the read as landed.

Leans

In battle, a lean may stand where "*What will … do?*" stood: what the other side is about to do. A lean is right more often as your reading grows, and never always.



A read on arrival, and a lean in battle.

Words under words

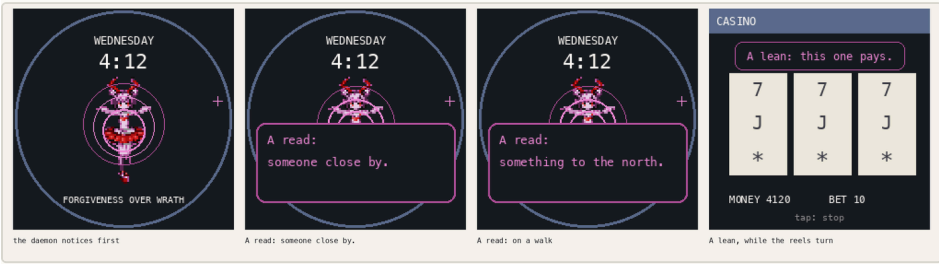
And now and then there is a faint purple line beneath what someone says: a few words they did not say aloud.



Words under words.

Out here too

Once your save holds the book, the companion's watches notice too: the daemon on the face stops and turns, a purple "**A read:**" comes with a soft tap, and at the CASINO's reels, sometimes, "**A lean:**" while they turn. The companion judges each by what happens after and keeps the count; it never says a read was right before it lands.



On a watch: the daemon notices first, two reads, and a lean at the reels. A mock-up drawn from the watch's own firmware, not a photograph; every word DRAFT.

CHAPTER 12

PLAY: the HARP and the FLUTE

Each edition has an instrument: **the HARP in CONTENT, the FLUTE in CONTEXT.** You are given it in the course of the story. Take it out and a **KEY WHEEL** of twelve keys opens; choose one, and it folds into a **STAFF**.



The KEY WHEEL, and a song written into the SONGBOOK as it is learned (CONTEXT's FLUTE).

the notes of the scale, one to seven	**DOWN, LEFT, UP, RIGHT, B, A, SELECT**
an octave up, or down	hold **R**, or **L**
put it away	**START**

Every note has its own colour -- C red, D orange, E yellow, F green, G blue, A indigo, B violet -- and stays bright in any light.

Seven songs

Seven songs are heard somewhere in the world. Play one back, in its key, and it is learned, and each does something of its own. **Some things in the world listen** -- and to them the right notes in the wrong key are not quite the same tune. What you learn is written in the **SONGBOOK**, in the notes' colours.

The companion has your instrument too: once the game has given it to you, its SONGBOOK lets you play it by touch, and it listens for your songs as the game does.

CHAPTER 13

The GAME CORNER and the CASINO

The GAME CORNER

The GAME CORNER's slot machines play with the daemons you have **seen**: as your INDEX fills, new ones come to the reels. A coin and the season's piece turn with them, and on a holiday the reels wear its hats. Luck comes from the game's own day -- the holiday, the sky, the hour and the season. Coins are kept in your **TOKEN CASE**.



A slot machine, and its reels.

The CASINO

The companion has a CASINO of its own, on the phone, the site, the Tab5 and every board: three reels of your own party. **Its coins are your game's money**: it starts from what your save holds, and the next SYNC writes what was won or lost into the save -- never below nothing and never past 999999. Its odds move with the day, between 90 and 100 back for every 100 bet, and **THE HOUSE** tells you today's odds and why.

CHAPTER 14

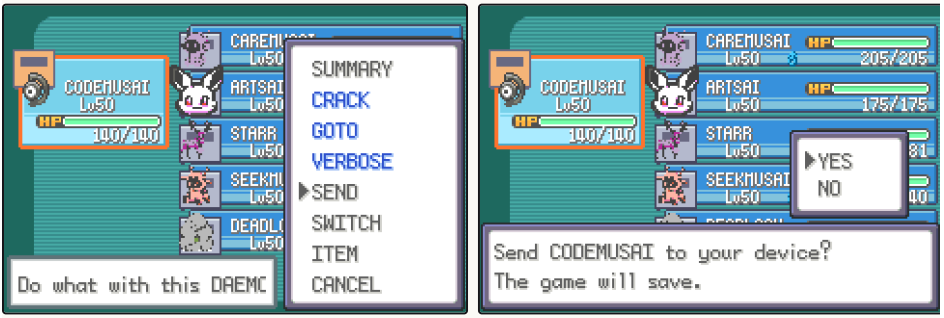
The companion

Your daemons can leave the game. daemons-companion lets your phone, a watch or a small board **host** a daemon from your party. You feed it, give it a drink, train it and put it to bed; you can talk with it; tell it what you want to get done and it turns that into **one next step**. As you get things done it thrives -- and it comes home to your save with what it learned.

Everything runs **on your own machines**: a local server, no accounts, no hosting. It reads a DAEMONS save -- a **copy** of yours -- and never needs a ROM.

SEND, AWAY and home

1. **Point the companion at a copy of your save** and SYNC once. From then on, a party daemon's menu in the game offers **SEND**.
2. **SEND** a daemon: the game saves, the companion reads the save and marks it **AWAY**, and a device of yours hosts it. With more than one device, each can host a different daemon.
3. **Bring it home** the same way, reversed. It comes back with the friendship it built -- and, if it crossed the line while it was out there, recompiled: the companion applies the game's own rules, and the game finishes the change.



SEND, from a daemon's menu in the party.

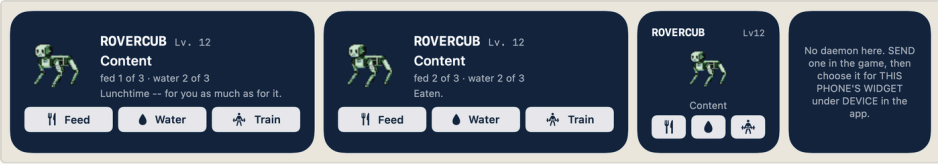
An AWAY daemon is drawn washed out in your party, the PORT and its summary, so it is never lost. It can't battle, be traded or be released while it is away, and if the companion can ever not be reached, the game can call it home on its own. While it is

away, the people who tend daemons between battles sometimes hear how it is doing -- well, fine or quiet, never worse. The companion calls these **SOUNDINGS**.

> **Never point the companion at the save you play from while the game is running.** SYNC writes the save, so it must never write one the game is about to write over. Every SYNC makes a backup first.

Where a daemon can live

your phone	the companion's app, on an iPhone or iPad, with a **home-screen widget** of its own: DRINK, FEED, TRAIN and, at bedtime, SLEEP
a browser	the companion's site, on the computer that runs it -- the same screens as the app
the one app	the game and the companion together on an iPhone or iPad (above)
a watch	the LilyGO **T-Watch S3**, and the bigger **T-Watch Ultra**, which knows when you sleep and walk, wakes you gently, reads you the books, and takes a card to its NFC
a board	most LilyGO and M5Stack boards: the T-Embed family, the T-Deck, the T-Display-S3 Pro and AMOLED, the M5StickS3 and StickC-Plus, the CoreS3, M5GO, Fire, Dial and Cardputer -- the daemon drawn as the game draws it, its routines with it
a control center	the M5Stack **Tab5**
your home	an ESP32-S3-BOX-3 running Home Assistant's voice assistant can wear the daemon as its face
a hub that never sleeps	a small Linux board (an M5Stack CoreMP135) can be the companion's server; with an AI board stacked on it, it talks as your daemon, tells its dreams, and answers as THE GUIDE once you have found it



The daemon on an iPhone's home screen: the widget, drawn from its real views, before and after FEED, small, and with no daemon chosen.

What it shows of your game

The app, the site and the Tab5 share six tabs, and **show only what your save has already reached** -- a MARK not yet earned, a place not yet found or a book not yet in your hands shows as *not yet*, and nothing more.

TODAY	the day's virtue over its shadow, its note and season, **THE ONE THING** -- the next step -- your daemon's care, and your game: where you saved, your MARKS, your money
DAEMON	yours and its care, your party as the game draws it, the **INDEX** with each daemon's NATIVE line, **SOUNDINGS**, **DREAMS** and, once the book is held, **READS**
GOALS	one goal, its steps and milestones, and walking
LIBRARY	CALLOW SCHOOL and your DIPLOMA, THE GUIDE and THE SUBTLE LAYER once found, the NOTEBOOK, the SONGBOOK with your instrument, and STREAM's lessons
YOU	you as the game draws you, your MARKS and ROOTS, the region maps, the story so far, and **THE ROAD AHEAD** -- the next step, and never anything past it
PLACES	your devices, which daemon each hosts, and your home

Nights and dreams

A watch keeps the night: tuck the daemon in (CARE, SLEEP), or on the T-Watch Ultra just sleep, and it feels the stillness. In the morning your daemon has had a dream -- deep, quiet or restless -- read aloud if you like and kept in a journal. At the next SYNC the last dream goes home into your save, for the game's **ITS DREAMS**. A good week shows on the daemon, subtly.

Running it

On the computer that keeps your save copy, with Node 24, from the companion's folder:

```
./bindCompanion.sh          # the server, then the site in your browser
./bindCompanion.sh phone    # build the app onto a plugged-in iPhone
./bindCompanion.sh always   # keep the server running, and the Mac awake on power
```

Then pair your phone from the site, add the widget, and SEND. The boards are flashed with `updateCompanion.sh` and linked over their USB cable with `linkCompanion.sh`. The companion's own wiki has every step, every board and every setting: **github.com/CodeMusic/daemons-companion/wiki**.

CHAPTER 15

Help

Something went wrong

what you see	what to do
Source checksum mismatch, or *wrong input file*	your ROM is not the version that patch was made for: try the other patch for your game (1.0 or Rev 1)
the title says FIRERED or LEAFGREEN	the patch was not applied: open the **patched** file, or check that a soft-patch's two names match
a white screen, or it will not start	usually a bad dump: dump the cartridge again
a long black screen at the start of a new game	wait a few seconds; a phone is slower than a computer
the date in the game is decades out (mGBA)	mGBA's clock in the save was never set. Back up the `.sav`, cut it to its first 131,072 bytes, and mGBA starts the clock again from your computer's
the flash cart does not read an mGBA save	cut it to exactly 131,072 bytes (`head -c 131072 in.sav > out.sav`); back up both copies first
the days do not follow the real date	no clock is being read: switch the cartridge's RTC on, and check with **TIME** at your bedroom's terminal
my old *FireRed* save does not work	it is not meant to: start a new game, under the DAEMONS ROM's own name

Updating to a new release

1. Copy your `.sav` somewhere safe.
2. Download the new patch for your ROM, and apply it to your **clean original** -- never to a ROM you already patched.
3. Give the result the **same file name** as before, so your emulator or cartridge finds the same save.

Reporting a bug

Open an issue at **github.com/CodeMusic/DAEMONS/issues** and say which release you are playing (it is in the release's name, like `v11.316.2`), which edition, and how you play it. Please leave out where hidden things are.

CHAPTER 16

Glossary

ADMINBOX, SUPERBOX, ROOTBOX -- better boxes for binding; a ROOTBOX never fails.

AWAY -- a daemon you SENT to the companion.

BENCHMARK -- a town's test, and its leader. Pass it for a MARK.

BINDING -- catching an UNBOUND daemon in a box.

CHECKPOINT -- where your daemons are restored, free.

COLD STORAGE -- where daemons wait past your six, through a PORT.

CRYSTAL CLEAR -- who keeps the lab in your home town.

DETACH -- to get away from a battle with an unbound daemon.

DRIVER -- teaches a routine that works outside battle too.

GOTO -- to a CHECKPOINT you have reached, in a flash of bits.

HALTED -- out of health. RESTART or REBOOT it, or visit a CHECKPOINT.

HEARSAY -- what people say about the people you meet.

INDEX -- the record of every daemon you meet.

KEY WHEEL -- where your instrument's key is chosen.

MARK -- a BENCHMARK's prize: a virtue over its shadow.

NATIVE -- where and when a daemon lives, in its INDEX entry.

NOTEBOOK -- the pages you find and write.

OPUS -- margins for the INDEX.

PERSPECTIVE -- R, held, in battle.

PLUGIN -- teaches a routine; kept in the TOOLKIT.

POOL -- your bag.

PORT -- a PC.

RECOMPILE -- what a daemon does when it becomes the next in its line.

ROLL CALL -- finds trainers who want a rematch.

ROOT -- an understanding you hold.

ROUTINE -- a move.

SEND -- out of the party, to the companion.

SITEMAP -- the map of everywhere.

SONGBOOK -- the songs you have learned.

STREAM -- lessons, replayed.

SUPPRESS -- keeps unbound daemons away for a while.

THE REPO -- the shop.

THE REVIEW BOARD -- the last four, and the one after them.

TOKEN CASE -- holds the GAME CORNER's coins.

TRAP TABLE -- holds what you grow and pick.

UNBOUND -- wild.

USER -- a trainer: you, and everyone you fight.

USERBOX -- the first box for binding.

CHAPTER 17

About this manual

This manual describes **v11.316.2**, built against the design bible **v11.316** (2026-10-28). It is made by `tools/manual.py` from `docs/manual/` in the DAEMONS repository, and printed again with each release: the daemons, their INDEX entries, the types, the chart and the patches are read from the build itself, and the game screens are frames captured from built ROMs in the project's test emulator. Every word quoted from the game is a draft.

DAEMONS is a fan project, unaffiliated with and unendorsed by Nintendo, Creatures Inc. or GAME FREAK Inc. Pokémon is their trademark. It is built on **pret**'s decompilations of *FireRed* (pokefirered) and *Red* (pokered), and would not exist without them. No ROM, and nothing of Nintendo's, is distributed: the project publishes patches for your own cartridge's game.

the game	github.com/CodeMusic/DAEMONS
its engine	github.com/CodeMusic/pokefirered-daemons
the companion	github.com/CodeMusic/daemons-companion
the playground	github.com/CodeMusic/daemons-playground